

The Bar for Hiring PMs Just Changed Completely. Here Are the 5 AI Skills You Must Have.

7 min read · Oct 30, 2025



Aakash Gupta

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Expectations of PMs in today's market



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Product Manager hiring is evolving—at least for me.

From now on, I want to see what's in a PM's toolbox:

- * What's in your prompt library?
- * What automations have you built to increase your speed and leverage?
- * What's in your GitHub?
- * What prototypes or passion projects show how you think and build?
- * What AI tools have you mastered and why?

The jobs will still be won with product taste, listening and empathy, the ability to create clarity and insight, and good old-fashioned work ethic. But if you don't have your own tools and practical knowledge, you're probably not ready. These are now the ante.



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I just reviewed 50 PM job descriptions from top companies.

Five years ago, they all looked the same. “Strong communication skills. User empathy. Technical fluency. Stakeholder management.”

Today, they're completely different.

Every single one mentions AI. But not in the vague “experience with AI products” way. They're asking for specific, demonstrable AI capabilities.

The bar for hiring PMs has fundamentally changed. Traditional PM skills are table stakes now. AI skills are the differentiator.

Here are the 5 AI competencies companies are actually hiring for in 2025.

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1. Prompt Library (Stop Writing Every Prompt From Scratch)

If you're still writing each prompt by hand, you're working at 20% efficiency.

The most productive PMs I know don't chat with AI tools. They have systematized prompt libraries.

What this actually looks like:

A saved collection of proven prompts for recurring tasks:

- Drafting a PRD
- Giving feedback on a strategy document
- Finding holes in a prototype
- Creating an LLM judge for evaluation
- Analyzing A/B test results
- Synthesizing customer feedback
- Generating user stories

Not generic prompts. Refined prompts that produce consistently good results.

The difference:

Without a prompt library:

Open ChatGPT → Type prompt from memory → Get mediocre results → Refine → Try again → Maybe get what you need after 15 minutes.

With a prompt library:

Pull up your tested prompt → Insert specifics → Get great results in 30 seconds.

That's a 30x time savings on a task you do daily.

The best PMs treat their prompt library like code. They version it. They test it. They share effective prompts with their team.

[Complete prompt library guide](#)

Hiring managers look for this. When they ask “how do you use AI in your workflow,” they’re really asking “have you systematized this or are you still winging it?”

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2. Automations (Beyond Chat Interfaces)

Using ChatGPT doesn't make you proficient at AI.

It makes you a consumer of AI tools. Companies want PMs who can build with AI.

The expectation: You can create automated workflows that run without you.

Tools You Should Know:

Zapier or Airtable for basic automation — Connect apps, trigger workflows, move data automatically.

Lindy or Relay for AI agent workflows — Build agents that make decisions and take actions based on context.

n8n or Cassidy for multi-agent systems — Orchestrate complex workflows with multiple AI agents working together.

What this looks like in practice:

A traditional PM manually checks support tickets for feature requests, copies them to a spreadsheet, and reviews weekly.

An AI-proficient PM builds an automation:

1. Agent monitors support tickets continuously
2. Identifies feature requests automatically
3. Extracts and categorizes them

4. Adds to Airtable with priority scoring

5. Sends weekly digest of top requests

Same outcome. Zero manual work.

Complete automation guide

In interviews, they'll ask: "Give an example of an automation you've built." If your answer is "I haven't," you're behind.

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3. GitHub Presence (The New PM Portfolio)

The expectation has flipped completely.

A few years ago, PMs showing GitHub repos was seen as trying too hard. "Focus on strategy, not code."

Now, having nothing on GitHub is a red flag.

Modern PMs are expected to be technical. Not full-stack engineers, but capable of:

- Vibe coding prototypes
- Contributing to open source projects
- Understanding what a repo is and how to use it
- Reading code well enough to review PRs

A great PM GitHub has:

AI prototypes — Working demos of AI features or products you've built. Not production code. Proof that you can build functional prototypes to test ideas.

AI context engineering — Examples of RAG implementations, fine-tuning experiments, prompt engineering systems. Shows you understand AI architecture.

Tangible side projects — Real things you've shipped that solve real problems. Evidence of execution, not just ideas.

Why this matters:

When you say “I prototyped an AI feature,” hiring managers want to see it. GitHub is where you show your work.

The PMs getting hired at top companies have public GitHub profiles with 5–10 projects. Each one is a portfolio piece proving they can actually build.

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4. Side Projects (From Red Flag to Green Flag)

The stigma around side projects has completely reversed.

Five years ago: “Why are you working on side projects? Aren’t you focused on your job?”

Today: “You don’t have side projects? Are you even serious about building products?”

The shift happened because side projects predict PM performance.

PMs with side projects:

- Ship faster (they’re used to moving without corporate bureaucracy)
- Think creatively (they’ve solved problems without big budgets)
- Understand users deeply (they’ve had to find their own customers)
- Execute relentlessly (nobody forced them to finish)

What wins in interviews:

AI wrappers that make money — Even \$500/month proves you can find a market, build something people pay for, and run a business.

AI services with paying customers — Consulting, productized services, anything where people exchange money for your AI expertise.

Free AI tools with lots of users — Distribution is hard. If you built something 10K+ people use, you understand growth.

Side project guide

The hiring signal:

Side projects prove you can see opportunities and execute on them. That's literally the PM job.

Candidates with side projects get hired 3x more often than those without. This isn't correlation. It's causation.

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5. AI Tool Fluency (Beyond the Obvious Ones)

Everyone uses ChatGPT. That's not a differentiator anymore.

Companies want PMs who are at the cutting edge of AI tools. Who try new tools immediately. Who know what's possible.

Categories worth knowing deeply:

AI Dictation Tools

Wispr Flow, SuperWhisper — Voice-to-text everywhere. Not just transcription. Actual tools that let you work 3x faster by speaking instead of typing.

If you write 2 hours per day and speaking is 3x faster, you save 80 minutes daily. That compounds fast.

AI Insights Tools

Enterpret, Unwrap, Dovetail — Aggregate thousands of customer feedback points and surface patterns automatically.

Traditional PMs manually read reviews. AI PMs have tools that synthesize everything and show trends in minutes.

AI Image Generation

Nano Banana, Midjourney, DALL-E — Not just for fun. For rapid mockups, marketing assets, prototyping visual concepts.

The ability to generate visual assets on demand changes how fast you can test ideas.

Complete AI tools guide

The expectation:

When a new AI tool launches, you've already tried it. You can speak knowledgeably about its strengths, limitations, and use cases.

In interviews: "What AI tools do you use beyond ChatGPT?" should generate a 5-minute answer, not "uh, Claude sometimes?"

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What This Actually Means for Your Career

Let's be direct about what's happening:

The PM job market is splitting into two tiers.

Tier 1: PMs with demonstrated AI capabilities. Prompt libraries. Automations. GitHub repos. Side projects. Tool fluency.

Tier 2: Traditional PMs who haven't adapted.

Tier 1 PMs are getting:

- More interview requests
- Higher compensation
- Better roles
- Faster career progression

Tier 2 PMs are getting:

- Fewer opportunities
- Pressure to "learn AI" without knowing how
- Passed over for roles they're qualified for

The gap is widening every month.

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The Timeline Nobody Talks About

Here's the uncomfortable truth:

You have maybe 12–18 months to develop these skills before they become absolutely mandatory.

Right now, they're "nice to have" at some companies and "required" at others.

By 2026, they'll be required everywhere.

The PMs who wait until then will be 2 years behind the curve. The ones who build these skills now will be unreachable.

This isn't hyperbole. This is the pattern every time a major technology shift happens.

Mobile in 2010. Cloud in 2015. AI in 2025.

The PMs who adapted early built incredible careers. The ones who waited struggled to catch up.

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How to Actually Build These Skills

Don't try to master everything at once.

Pick one skill. Spend a month getting genuinely good at it. Then add the next.

Prompt Library

Start here — Build your collection of proven prompts. Use them daily. Refine constantly.

Basic Automations

Start here — Pick one workflow. Automate it end-to-end. Learn Zapier or Lindy.

First Prototype

Start here — Build something small but functional. Put it on GitHub.

Side Project

Start here — Ship something people can actually use. Even if it's tiny.

Tool Exploration

Start here — Try 10 new AI tools. Find the ones that actually improve your workflow.

Not master level. But demonstrable capability. Which is what hiring managers are looking for.

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The New PM Interview

Traditional PM interviews tested:

- Product sense
- Execution
- Strategy
- Leadership
- Technical fluency

Modern AI PM interviews add:

- “Walk me through your prompt library”
- “Show me an automation you’ve built”
- “What’s on your GitHub?”
- “Tell me about your side projects”
- “What AI tools do you use and why?”

If you can’t answer these confidently, you’re not competitive anymore.

The bar has changed. The expectations have shifted.

In 2025, every PM has to become an AI PM.

Not because it's trendy. Because it's how the job is actually done now.

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Your Choice

You can wait. Hope this is a passing trend. Keep doing PM the way it's always been done.

Or you can adapt.

Build the prompt library. Create the automations. Ship the side projects. Master the tools.

The companies hiring right now are looking for AI-capable PMs.

The ones who wait will be looking for jobs that require skills they don't have.

Which PM will you be?

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The resources are linked above. The path is clear. The only question is whether you'll take it.

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Responses (2)



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What are your thoughts?



Eric Tollefson

Nov 1



Every single one mentions AI. But not in the vague “experience with AI products” way. They’re asking for specific, demonstrable AI capabilities.

Not sold AI will do the trick for Project Managers. I am on the sidelines and have observed the limited capabilities of AI. I have witnessed someone doing multiple iterations with ChatGPT only to have produced substandard documents. Jury is still... [more](#)



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Tim Nunn

2 days ago



Maybe in the bubble that is Silicone Valley, but not in the real world. The real world still knows human skills outsize any technical skills at least 10x.



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